India, the USA was an option only for those who had the means and the skills.

Indians migrated in three clearly discernible waves.[36] Between 1965 and the late 1970s, highly educated Indians, especially from the newly established Indian Institutes of Technology, moved to work in the science, engineering and medical fields. This was followed by a phase of family reunification until the mid-90s when the spouses and children joined the early emigrants. These migrations were labelled the ‘brain drain’ in India, a concept that will be discussed in the final chapter. Since the mid-90s, the boom in the Information and Technology (IT) sector led to the mass migration of computer engineers and students who got jobs there. The major areas of Indian settlements have been the New York–New Jersey cluster, Silicon Valley or San Francisco Bay area, Washington D.C., Chicago, Houston and Dallas. While Gujaratis and Punjabis dominated the earlier waves of migration, the latter phase was dominated by south Indians, especially Telugus and Tamilians, as private computer training schools proliferated in the region since the 1980s. Districts like Anand in Gujarat and Guntur in coastal Andhra Pradesh thus became major sites of American emigration and received large amount of remittances and diasporic philanthropy in return. Similarly, Bengaluru and Hyderabad forged close connections with American NRIs for entrepreneurial ventures and investments in real estate.

The craze to go to the USA was, and is still, evident in the numerous computer coaching centres that have sprung up in India and the premium placed on ‘America boys’ in the marriage market, much like what is was for ‘Bombay boys’ in Ratnagiri district. In Andhra Pradesh, an engineering degree and an American visa are considered to be rites of passage towards upward mobility. The variety of visa acronyms such as B-1, L-1, F-1 and H1B and the loopholes in the visa system are also discussed threadbare. When the H1N1 pandemic broke out in 2009, a popular refrain in India was that the queues at the American embassy had grown longer as people thought it was a new visa that the Americans were offering.